Claude Code, Skills & n8n

A practical guide to understanding what they are, how they differ, and how they work together

---

1. What is Claude Code?

Claude Code is Anthropic's official CLI (Command Line Interface) and agent environment. It is not just the Claude AI model — it is a full development environment where Claude has access to powerful built-in tools and can take real actions on your behalf.

Built-in tools available in Claude Code:

- File reading, editing, and writing
- Running bash/shell commands
- GitHub MCP tools (create PRs, comment on issues, merge branches)
- Web search and web fetching
- Spawning sub-agents for parallel tasks

Claude Code runs either on your local machine or in a remote cloud container (like this session). It is a developer tool — something you interact with to build, fix, and maintain things.

2. What are Skills?

Skills are pre-built multi-step workflows built into the Claude Code environment. They are triggered with a /command and automate complex sequences of actions.

Examples of available skills:

Skill	What it does
/autopilot	End-to-end task: plan → implement → review → open PR
/bugfix	Reproduce the bug → root-cause → fix → regression test → PR
/code-review	Review a diff for bugs and improvements, post inline comments
/deep-research	Multi-source web research with fact-checking and cited report
/docs	Generate or update documentation for a feature or API
/security-review	Security audit of pending branch changes
/dashboard	Build a metrics/monitoring dashboard
/investigate	Root-cause investigation with competing hypotheses

Important: Skills are defined at the platform level by Anthropic. You cannot create new skills, but you can achieve similar behavior by writing a CLAUDE.md file with instructions.

3. What is CLAUDE.md?

CLAUDE.md is a Markdown file you create in your repository. Claude reads it at the start of every session and treats it as standing instructions for that project. It is essentially your way of customizing Claude's behavior for your specific codebase.

What you can put in CLAUDE.md:

- Which tools to prefer for specific tasks (e.g. always use MCP tools for GitHub, not gh CLI)
- Files or folders Claude should never touch
- Coding conventions and style rules
- What to run before committing (e.g. npm test)
- Architecture decisions and context
- Repeatable workflows Claude should follow

	System Prompt	CLAUDE.md
Who controls it	Anthropic	You
Scope	All Claude sessions everywhere	This repo only
Can you edit it?	No	Yes
Purpose	Core behavior and capabilities	Project-specific instructions

4. What is n8n?

n8n is a visual workflow automation platform. You build workflows using a node-based editor and connect services together. It runs 24/7, triggered by events (webhooks, schedules, etc.), and executes your business logic automatically without human interaction.

Key characteristics of n8n:

- Always-on, event-driven automation
- Visual drag-and-drop workflow builder
- Connects to hundreds of services (Supabase, Slack, Gmail, etc.)
- You can use Claude as the LLM inside an AI Agent node (via API key)
- The agent only has access to nodes you wire up — not Claude Code's full toolset
- Best for production, runtime workflows

5. Key Differences

	Claude Code	n8n AI Agent	Fleet/SDK Agent
Uses Claude model	Yes	Yes (via API)	Yes (via API)
File & bash tools	Yes (built-in)	No	You build them
Skills	Yes (built-in)	No	You build them
Visual builder	No	Yes	No

Runs 24/7	No	Yes	Depends
Custom workflows	CLAUDE.md	n8n nodes	Code
Best for	Building & maintaining	Production runtime	Custom agents

> The analogy: telling someone to "dump n8n for Claude Code" is like saying "dump your car for a hammer" — they are not competing, they serve entirely different purposes.

6. How They Complement Each Other

The smart approach is to use Claude Code and n8n together. Here is a real example:

Example: Customer Support Workflow

Phase	Tool	What happens
Build	Claude Code + Skills	Design schema, write Supabase queries, build n8n workflow JSON, w
Maintain	Claude Code	Fix bugs, review PRs, update prompts, refactor queries as requireme
Run	n8n	Intent agent receives message → queries Supabase via MCP → resp

Other ways Claude Code helps you build n8n workflows:

- Write and test the system prompts for each AI Agent node
- Design and create the Supabase schema and RLS policies
- Generate the n8n workflow JSON definition from a description
- Review and audit your workflow for security issues (/security-review)
- Research the best architecture for your use case (/deep-research)
- Document the entire system (/docs)

7. Summary

Tool	One-liner
Claude Code	A developer assistant with powerful tools — you use it to BUILD things
Skills	Pre-built multi-step workflows inside Claude Code (/autopilot, /bugfix, etc.)
CLAUDE.md	Your custom instructions file — extends Claude's behavior for your repo
n8n	Visual automation platform — runs your workflows in production 24/7
Fleet/SDK	Build your own custom agents on top of the Claude API in code

---